As the session approached, both sides were spoiling for a fight. VOC considered Tilak his political guru and was firmly on his side. In hectic correspondence with Tilak and Aurobindo Ghose in trying to get Lajpat Rai, rather than the moderate Rash Behari Ghose elected to preside over the session, VOC arrived at Madras on 18 December, ahead of his departure to Surat.[3] Three days later, on the 21st, VOC headed 'a nationalist delegation' that included Subramania Bharati, V. Chakkarai Chettiar, Ethiraj Surendranath Arya, N.K. Ramaswamy Aiyar and S. Duraiswamy Aiyar. Amidst loud shouts of 'Vande Mataram', the contingent left for Bombay by a separate railway carriage with the banner 'The Madras Nationalists' pinned to it.[4] VOC shared the expenses of the trip with Mandayam Srinivasachari.[5] As he was a seasoned person familiar with Bombay—he had travelled and lived in the city over the past year on shipping business—VOC guided the group around the city before leaving for Surat. Apart from the political significance of the event, VOC was keenly looking forward to meeting Tilak, his political hero, for the first time.

With a showdown imminent, the Moderates too mobilized in good numbers. From Madras presidency, B.K. Ramaier and K.R. Guruswami Aiyar—both with strong connections to SSNCo—went to Surat.[6] Guruswami Aiyar, despite his many preoccupations—including the ongoing session of the Madras Legislative Council—was inclined to give it a miss but was persuaded by fellow Moderates V. Krishnaswamy Aiyar and L.A. Govindaraghava Iyer to attend the session.[7]

As anticipated, the Congress session proved to be tumultuous. On 27 December, as Rash Behari Ghose stood up to present his presidential address, a slipper—'the Maratha chappal'—thrown from the crowd brushed the moderate leaders Pherozeshah Mehta and Surendranath Banerjea. There was utter chaos as hired goons entered the pandal wielding sticks. The pandemonium was contained only after the police entered the scene. The Congress was now vertically split and weakened—a decade would pass before it could become a powerful mass movement under Gandhi.